12. Mass Media

Breakout Sessions

POLS 1101

8:40am-9:35am Baldwin 322

& 9:55am-10:50am Journalism 509

SIYUAN (Siri) ZHAO

Siri.Zhao@uga.edu

https://siyuanzhao-pa.github.io/

Mass Media

- **Let's start with a 1-minute survey on media use!**
  - https://docs.google.com/forms/d/e/1FAIpQLSe3q-iFrKqRap3mm4DM5AIQpfQA0usdzl7KyOl7rcL1dZcTiQ/viewform?usp=dialog

- **Reflections**
  - Do you browse political news, or just use media for entertainment?
  - Do your parents / grandparents like browsing political news? through which channel(s)?
  - What kind of political news do you like?
    - Elections
    - Federal Government & policy
    - Local issues
    - International news
    - Social issues
    - Political debates & scandals
  - Are you aware of some **media bias** & your **selection bias** of sources of information?
  - Do you have the habit of verifying the accuracy of information in daily life?

Private Ownership of the Media

- **The consequences of private ownership**
  - Market-driven entertaining news – newsworthiness lies in audience appeal.
    - E.g. **infotainment / soft news**: a mix of information and diversion oriented to personalities or celebrities; not linked to the day's events, and usually unrelated to public affairs / policy.
  - Concentration effects (Natural monopoly?)

- **Government regulation of the private media**
  - **You're advising a state committee drafting media-regulation principles. Consider:**
    (1) legitimate reason(s) for regulation,
    (2) red line(s) that must not be crossed,
    (3) workable compromise rule(s) (who regulates what, and how regulators are checked).

  As groups, each designs a regulatory framework. (See next slide)

  - **What could happen if media were controlled by the government?**
    - The core puzzle isn't just bias; it's who controls information channels, for what reasons, and at what kind of cost.

APPENDIX 1

Regulatory Framework / Regulatory Action Plan

1. Policy Objective

- What problem does the regulation aim to address?
- Why is government intervention necessary (or not)?

2. Scope of Regulation

- Who (scope) and what (Target) will be regulated?
  - Scope: broadcast / press / platforms / AIGC / …
  - Target: platforms / advertisers / recommender algorithms /

3. Regulatory Instruments

- What tools: e.g. Rules, standards, incentives, or penalties
- Why these tools?

4. Implementation Mechanism

- Responsible agencies
- Timeline and procedures

5. Due Process & Accountability

- Appeals / complaint process
- Oversight of the regulator

6. Stakeholder Involvement

- Public consultation
- Role of interest groups and experts

7. Evaluation and Adjustment

- Performance indicators
- Review and revision process

APPENDIX 2

Potential Models You Could Use

Model A. Minimal content regulation

- Government only regulates **spectrum / licensing / competition**, with content disputes mostly handled by courts (defamation, incitement).

Model B. Independent regulator for broadcast

- An **independent regulator** sets broadcast standards (accuracy, hate speech boundaries, …), with due process/appeals.

Model C. Press self-regulation

- Press council/self-regulation with **ethics codes** + **complaint process** (corrections, apologies, published rulings).
- No direct regulation from the government.

Model D. Co-regulation with platforms

- Government doesn't decide each piece of content; it only mandates **risk assessment, transparency reporting, algorithm audits, and appeals**.

Model E. Illegal-content takedown obligations

- Penalties for **clearly illegal** content (terrorism, CSAM, explicit incitement).

Model F. State-directed correction/takedown

(More like an authoritarian censorship)

- Government can order corrections/takedowns for "false" information.

Different combinations of freedom, order, and equality

Functions of the Mass Media

- **Reporting the news:** How the media cover political affairs
  - President: through the Office of the Press Secretary (e.g. news release); Truth Social?
  - Congress: press releases, congressional reports, members' social networking accounts

- **Interpreting and presenting:** What can become news **("Gatekeeper")**
  - ***Horse race journalism*** in elections – because individuals have attractive personalities!
  - **Media events** that the mass media are compelled to cover (major public occasions)
  - **Television hypothesis**: Television is to blame for the low level of citizens' political knowledge (*fragmental information, personal view, under regulation of FCC* – all of these can discourage respect for different opinions and lead to political distrust)

Functions of the Mass Media (cont`d)

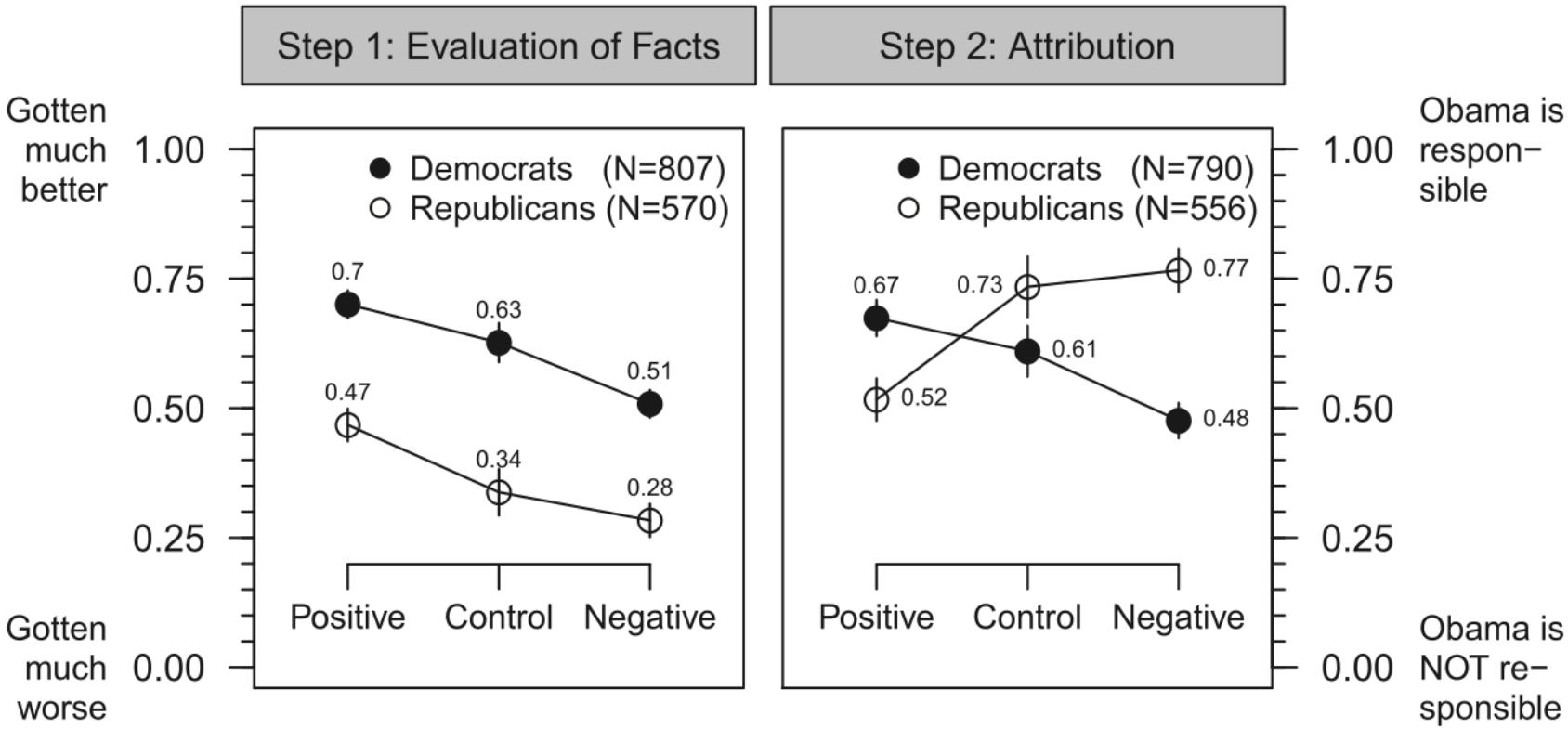
- **Claims of ideological bias among the mass media may be overblown. (Supplemental Reading Material)**
  - Journalists are liberal, but there are no gatekeeping bias and minimal framing bias.
    - Journalists were just as likely to respond to very conservative candidates as very progressive candidates. They weren't more interested in covering a candidate of their own ideology.
    - Conservative newspapers are not overt Trump cheerleaders, and liberal outlets are not overly negative.

Functions of the Mass Media (cont`d)

- **Setting the political agenda:** What news is important
  - **Drawing citizens' attention, shaping "what is important"** in the mass public, and
  - **Identifying what requires government attention**
  - Consequence: **priming effect** (through issue manipulation);
    framing effect (through opposing issues)

- **Socializing the citizenry:** What people remember and learn
  - A channel for young people to be "socialized" (discussed before)
  - Reinforce the hegemony of existing culture and order
  - **Contradictory roles**: to promote popular support for government, or to erode public confidence
  - **According to your own experience, is political socialization through media primarily a cognitive process (learning information) or an affective process (developing attachments and identities)?**

FIGURE 2 Partisans Update Their Economic Perceptions in a Parallel Fashion, but Polarize in the Attribution of Responsibility (United States)



Evaluating the Mass Media

- **Bias do exist (to some extent), but it doesn't matter sometimes.**
  - Value-freedom is merely ideal type! And people can have "self-selection".

- **Contributions to democracy**
  - **Watchdog journalism**: Journalism that scrutinizes public and business institutions and publicizes perceived misconduct.
  - **Use their polling expertise**: to generate more accurate knowledge of public opinion, and to report that knowledge to public officials as well as to the public - majoritarianism.
  - **Professional ethics:** the capacity for in-depth investigation and fact-checking

Next week…

- Read materials on **Public Opinion** before class, and that will be helpful to participate in peer discussions.
- Feel free to email me if you have any questions!
- ENJOY YOUR WEEKEND!